Family Sharing Circle

Civic Skill: Difference | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 1 (Identity) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will share one thing their family does or values, and practise responding to others' family traditions with genuine curiosity rather than comparison or judgement.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can share something my family does or loves.
- I can ask a curious question about someone else's family — not 'that's weird' but 'I wonder why?'
- I can say one thing I learned about a different family.

MATERIALS

- A 'family treasure' item or photo brought from home (ask families a week in advance; anything is valid)
- A circle mat or special sharing space
- A 'question ball' — a soft ball passed to signal whose turn it is to ask a question
- Picture book: 'Families, Families, Families!' by Suzanne Lang, or 'The Family Book' by Todd Parr

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. FAMILY BOOK READ (5 min): Read 'Families, Families, Families!' Pause frequently: 'Is that like your family? Is that different? Both are wonderful.' Set the norm: all families are real families.

2. SHARING CIRCLE PROTOCOL (2 min): Establish the rules together — 'When someone shares, we listen. When they finish, we ask ONE question. Not 'I have one of those too' — a real question about THEM.'

3. SHARING ROUND 1 (10 min): Each child who wishes to share takes the floor. They show their item and say: 'In my family, we ___.' After each share, the group asks ONE question using the question ball.

4. QUESTION COACHING (ongoing): If a child asks a comparison ('we do it differently'), redirect gently: 'Can you ask it as a curiosity? Like 'I wonder why...'' This is the key skill — coach it in the moment.

5. CLOSING (3 min): 'What is one thing you learned about someone else's family today that you didn't know before?' Each child says one thing. Display on a 'Things We Learned' wall.

EXTENSIONS

- Create a class book: 'In Our Families' — each child contributes one page
- Display a world map and mark where families have connections or heritage
- Invite a family member to share a skill, recipe, or story from their culture or background

ASSESSMENT

- Note: Did children ask genuine questions or reframe around their own experience?
- Observe: Were there children who didn't bring an item or chose not to share? Follow up individually — don't make this a source of exclusion
- Learning story: document the sharing and question moment for each child

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Were there families whose lives don't fit the mainstream image of 'family'? How did you actively make space for them?
- What questions surprised you — in their insight or their difficulty?
- How will you sustain curiosity about family diversity beyond this one session?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 1 (Identity). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.